

Congregational Polity Position

doc-congregational-polity-position

Leadership & Polity · Polity · doctrine · divided_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across many Bible texts
Subject covered by a category in Scripture
Holds across manuscript variants

Statement under examination

Congregational polity (final earthly authority resting in the gathered congregation under Christ, with elders leading and the assembly affirming) best preserves NT autonomy and accountability.

In plain language

The verses behind this question describe how the first assemblies (ekklēsia, meaning 'assembly' or 'church') chose people and disciplined wrongdoers, and the words fall into two streams that the text never ranks against each other. One stream gives the gathered body a real and active part. In Acts 6 the whole multitude (plēthos) is pleased and 'chose' (exelexanto) the seven; in Matthew 18 the wronged believer is told to 'tell the assembly' (the ekklēsia); in 1 Corinthians 5 the congregation is commanded to 'judge' (krinate) and to 'remove' (exarate) the evil person from among themselves; and in 2 Corinthians 2 the penalty is one inflicted 'by the majority' (hypo tōn pleionōn). The other stream gives appointed leaders real authority. In Acts 6 the twelve apostles frame the task and do the 'appointing' (katastēsomen, from kathistēmi); in Acts 14 and Titus 1 traveling workers and a delegate 'appoint' (cheirotoneō and kathistēmi) elders city by city as 'instructed' (diatassō); in 1 Timothy 5 elders are said to 'rule' or 'preside' (proistēmi); and in Hebrews 13 believers are told to 'obey' (peithō) and 'submit' (hypeikō) to their leaders (hēgoumenoi, from hēgeomai). The trouble is that the strongest single word on each side is a word that appears only once in the whole New Testament (a hapax). The command 'remove' (exairō) in 1 Corinthians 5 and the command 'submit' (hypeikō) in Hebrews 13 are each one of a kind, so neither can be compared with other uses to settle its weight. The main leadership words, 'lead' (hēgeomai) and 'rule' (proistēmi), also carry more than one meaning across the New Testament, where 'lead' more often means to consider or regard, and 'rule' elsewhere means to manage a household. Because the same passages clearly show both whole assembly participation and authoritative appointed leadership, and because the sharpest terms cannot be cross checked, the words do not single out the congregation, or the elders, or a wider connected body, as the one final earthly authority. On top of that, the claim that one arrangement best preserves autonomy and accountability is a comparison and a value judgment that the words on the page cannot decide. For these reasons the lexical (word-level) pattern is genuinely contested and fairly supports more than one reading of how authority is ordered.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	80
G1577	ἐκκλησία	ekklēsia	assembly	115
G1586	ἐκλέγομαι	eklegomai	to select	22
G1808	ἐξαίρω	exairō	to expel	1
G2233	ἡγέομαι	hēgeomai	to govern	28
G2525	καθίστημι	kathistēmi	to appoint/conduct	22

G2919	κρίνω	krinō	to judge	115
G3982	πείθω	peithō	to persuade	54
G4119	πλείων	pleiōn	greater	45
G4128	πλήθος	plēthos	multitude	32
G4245	πρεσβύτερος	presbuteros	elder	
G4291	προΐστημι	proistēmi	to set before	8
G4862	σύν	syn	with	132
G4863	συνάγω	synagō	to assemble	61
G5226	ὑπείκω	hypeikō	to submit	1
G5500	χειροτονέω	cheirotoneō	to appoint	4

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: False

The cited texts attest two streams of vocabulary that the words do not rank. One stream gives the gathered body real action: the multitude (plēthos) is pleased and chose (exelexanto) the seven in Acts 6:5, the assembly (ekklēsia) is told (eipate tē ekklēsia, 'tell it to the assembly') in Matthew 18:17, the congregation is commanded to judge and remove (krinate, exarate) in 1 Corinthians 5:12-13, and a penalty is inflicted by the majority (hypo tōn pleionōn, 'by the more') in 2 Corinthians 2:6. The other stream gives appointed leaders real authority: the Twelve frame and 'will appoint' (katakatastēsomen, Acts 6:3), Titus and Paul 'appoint' elders (katestēsēn, Titus 1:5; 'they appointed by show of hands', echeirotoneōsan, Acts 14:23), elders 'rule' or 'preside' (proestōtes, 1 Timothy 5:17), and believers are to 'obey' and 'submit' to their leaders (peithesthe, hypeikete, hēgoumenois, Hebrews 13:17). The two sharpest commands, 'remove' (exarate) and 'submit' (hypeikete), each rest on a hapax verb (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), since both 'remove' (exairō) and 'submit' (hypeikō) occur only once, and the chief leadership verbs 'lead/consider' (hēgeomai) and 'preside/manage' (proistēmi) are polysemous (carry more than one meaning), so neither stream can be triangulated (checked against parallel uses) to outrank the other. The proposition's comparative claim that one arrangement best preserves autonomy and accountability is an evaluative judgment outside lexical reach, so the pattern is materially contested.

Scripture

Matt.18.17 · neutral · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1577 ἐκκλησία, G2919 κρίνω

Reasoning. The command directs the offended believer to 'tell it to the assembly or church' (eipate tē ekklēsia) in Matthew 18:17 and, if the offender will not hear, to treat him as an outsider ('Gentile', ethnikos, and 'tax collector', telōnēs). The assembly (ekklēsia) is the terminal court (the final stop) in this disciplinary sequence, but the verse does not say whether the assembly acts as an undifferentiated body or through its leaders, so it grounds congregational involvement without isolating a sole congregational authority.

Acts.6.3 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος, G2525 καθίστημι

Reasoning. The Twelve frame the action in Acts 6:3: 'look out from among yourselves' (episkepsasthe ex hymōn) seven attested men 'whom we will appoint' (katakatastēsomen). The selecting is handed to the body, but the framing imperative (command) and the appointing verb 'appoint' (kathistēmi) sit with the apostles, so authority is shared and sequenced, not concentrated in the congregation.

Acts.6.5 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4128 πλῆθος, G1586 ἐκλέγομαι

Reasoning. In Acts 6:5 the proposal 'pleased the whole multitude' (ēresen enōpion pantos tou plēthous, with plēthos meaning 'multitude' or 'whole body') and they 'chose' (exelexanto) the seven. The congregational selection is explicit and active here, which is genuine evidence for an assembly role, but the choosing follows apostolic instruction rather than originating final authority.

Acts.15.22 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0652 ἀπόστολος, G1577 ἐκκλησία, G4862 σύν

Reasoning. In Acts 15:22 'it seemed good to the apostles and the elders with the whole church or assembly' (syn holē tē ekklēsia, where ekklēsia means 'assembly' or 'church') to choose and send 'leading men' (andras hēgoumenous, 'men who lead'). The preposition 'with' (syn) conjoins (joins together) three actors and the decision is corporate (collective) and translocal (across multiple locations), sent out to other assemblies, but the grammar names apostles and elders first and joins the church to them, which complicates both a sole-congregation reading and a purely local reading.

Acts.14.23 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5500 χειροτονέω, G1577 ἐκκλησία

Reasoning. In Acts 14:23 Paul and Barnabas 'appointed elders by show of hands or installation' (cheirotoneōsantes, the participle of cheirotoneō) for them 'in every church or assembly' (kat' ekklēsia, with ekklēsia meaning 'assembly' or 'church') and selected presbyterous (elders). The subject of the appointing verb is the visiting apostles, not the local assembly (ekklēsia), so the verb of installation here sits with translocal (across-location) workers, which complicates a reading that lodges the establishment of leaders in the gathered congregation.

Titus.1.5 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2525 καθίστημι

Reasoning. In Titus 1:5 Paul left Titus in Crete to 'appoint elders in every city' (katastēsēs kata polin presbyterous, from kathistēmi 'to appoint') 'as I directed you' (hōs egō soi diatexamēn, from diatassō 'to direct or order'). The appointing verb 'appoint' (kathistēmi) and the directive verb 'direct' (diatassō) both rest on a delegate (representative) acting under apostolic instruction, not on the assembly, complicating a congregation-as-final-authority reading.

1Tim.5.17 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4291 προϊστημι

Reasoning. In 1 Timothy 5:17 'the elders who rule well or preside well' (hoi kalōs proestōtes presbyteroi, with the participle of proistēmi meaning 'rule' or 'preside') are to be counted worthy of double honor. The participle of 'rule/preside' (proistēmi) ascribes a governing function to elders, but this same verb elsewhere means 'manage a household' (1 Timothy 3:4-5, 12) and 'devote oneself to good works' (Titus 3:8, 14), so its sense here is read by context and does not by itself settle how far elder rule extends over the assembly.

Heb.13.17 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2233 ἡγέομαι, G3982 πείθω, G5226 ὑπείκω

Reasoning. In Hebrews 13:17 'obey your leaders and submit to them' (peithesthe tois hēgoumenois hymōn kai hypeikete, with peithō 'obey', hēgeomai 'lead' or 'consider', and hypeikō 'submit'), for they keep watch over your souls. Three verbs stack to enjoin deference to leaders. 'Submit' (hypeikō) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible, its only occurrence), and 'lead/consider' (hēgeomai) in the 'lead' sense is the minority sense of a word that more often means 'consider' or 'regard', so the strength of the leadership claim rests on words that cannot be triangulated (checked against parallel uses).

1Cor.5.4 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4863 συνάγω

Reasoning. In 1 Corinthians 5:4 'when you are gathered together' (synachthentōn hymōn, from synagō 'to gather together') with my spirit and the power of the Lord Jesus, the assembly is to act. The body convenes and executes discipline, supporting congregational agency, but Paul states in verse 3 that he 'has already judged' (kekrika, from krinō 'to judge') the case, so the determination precedes the assembly that carries it out.

1Cor.5.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2919 κρίνω, G1808 ἐξαίρω

Reasoning. In 1 Corinthians 5:13 'do you not judge those inside' (tous esō hymeis krinete, from krinō 'to judge')? 'Remove the evil one from among yourselves' (exarate ton ponēron ex hymōn autōn, from exairō 'to remove'). The plural commands place the act of removal on the whole body, strong support for congregational accountability, yet 'remove' (exairō) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) occurring only here, so this sharpest congregational command cannot be checked against any parallel use of the same verb.

2Cor.2.6 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4119 πλείων

Reasoning. In 2 Corinthians 2:6 'the punishment inflicted by the majority' (hē epitimia hautē hē hypo tōn pleionōn, with pleiōn meaning 'more' or 'the majority') is sufficient. The phrase 'by the more' or 'by the majority' points to corporate (collective) disciplinary action by the body, supporting congregational participation, but it describes a past practice rather than defining a constitutional seat of final authority, and 'more/majority' (pleiōn) is a common comparative whose force here is supplied by context.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
1Cor.5.5	1Cor.5.13	tsk	1
1Cor.5.13	1Cor.5.1	tsk	1
Acts.6.5	Acts.15.22	tsk	1
Acts.6.5	Acts.6.3	tsk	1
Acts.15.22	Acts.15.23	tsk	1
Acts.6.3	Acts.1.21	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.6.3 · addressed

In Acts 6:3 the Twelve direct the selection and reserve the appointing (katastēsomen 'we will appoint', from kathistēmi 'to appoint') and laying on of hands to themselves, so the episode shows shared and sequenced authority rather than congregational finality. Weighed in the verdict as a counter to a sole-congregation reading.

Acts.15.22 · addressed

In Acts 15:22 the 'with' (syn) construction joins the whole church or assembly (ekklēsia) to the apostles and elders, who are named first, and the decision is sent translocally (across locations). The text supports corporate (collective) decision-making but does not lexically (at the word level) isolate the congregation as the final earthly authority, nor restrict the action to one local body, recorded as material contestation.

Acts.14.23 · addressed

In Acts 14:23 the subject of 'appoint by show of hands' (cheirotoneō 'appoint, install') is the visiting apostles, not the local assembly, so the installation of elders is performed by translocal (across-location) workers here. This complicates locating the establishment of leaders in the gathered congregation and is weighed against a pure-congregational reading.

Titus.1.5 · addressed

In Titus 1:5 Titus, a delegate (representative) acting as Paul 'directed' (diatassō 'to direct or order'), 'appoints' (kathistēmi 'to appoint') elders city by city. The appointing authority runs through a delegate under apostolic instruction, not through the assembly, and the verdict treats this as unresolved between readings.

1Tim.5.17 · addressed

In 1 Timothy 5:17 'rule/preside' (proistēmi) ascribes a ruling function to elders, but the same verb means 'manage a household' and 'devote oneself to good works' elsewhere, so its governing scope is read from context and does not by itself rank elder rule above or below assembly action. Recorded as polysemy (multiple meanings) that the texts do not resolve.

Heb.13.17 · addressed

In Hebrews 13:17 'obey' (peithesthe, from peithō) and 'submit' (hypeikete, from hypeikō) enjoin obedience and submission to leaders ('leaders', hēgoumenois, from hēgeomai 'to lead' or 'to consider'), but 'submit' (hypeikō) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible) and 'lead' (hēgeomai) in the 'lead' sense is a minority sense, so the strength of this leadership claim rests on words that cannot be triangulated (checked against parallel uses). The texts attest leader authority without lexically (at the word level) ranking it against congregational action.

1Cor.5.3 · addressed

In 1 Corinthians 5:3 Paul writes that he has 'already judged' (kekrika, the perfect tense form of krinō 'to judge', meaning a completed action whose result still stands) the matter and the gathered body is to ratify and execute. The apostolic judgment preceding the assembly action complicates locating final authority in the congregation, treated as unresolved between readings.

Concordance traversed

G1577, G4128, G1586, G2919, G1808, G4119, G4863, G0652, G2525, G5500, G4291, G2233, G3982, G5226, G4862, G4245

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

The bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope=true and supplies no variant units for the cited verses, all outside the ingested ECM (the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) window of 3 John. Marginal sigla (the editorial symbols in the margins) appear in the supplied text (for example the reading at Acts 6:3 between 'we will appoint' (katastēsomen) and 'we should appoint' (katastēsōmen), and at 1 Corinthians 5:5 over the divine name), but none bears on whether authority rests with the assembly or its leaders, so the verdict holds across plausible readings.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. congregationalism, presbyterianism, connectionalism, apostolic_foundationalism

analogia scripturae invoked

congregationalism: partly_supported · Reads the whole-body verbs as decisive: the multitude 'chose' (exelexanto, from eklegomai 'to choose'; plēthos 'multitude' or 'whole body', Acts 6:5), the assembly (ekklēsia) is addressed as the court ('tell it to the assembly', eipate tē ekklēsia, Matthew 18:17), the congregation is commanded to 'judge' and 'remove' (krinate from krinō 'to judge'; exarate from exairō 'to remove'; 1 Corinthians 5:12-13), and discipline is by

the majority ('by the more', hypo tōn pleionōn, from pleiōn 'more' or 'majority'; 2 Corinthians 2:6). On this reading final earthly action sits with the gathered body. The texts supply real and active congregational agency, but they never state that final authority rests in the congregation, and the sharpest command 'remove' (exarate) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible).

presbyterianism: partly_supported · Reads the elder-rule verbs as decisive: elders 'rule' or 'preside' (proestōtes, the participle of proistēmi 'to rule' or 'to preside', 1 Timothy 5:17), believers 'obey' and 'submit' to leaders (peithesthe from peithō 'to obey'; hypeikete from hypeikō 'to submit'; hēgoumenois 'leaders' from hēgeomai 'to lead'; Hebrews 13:17), and elders are installed by appointment ('appoint', kathistēmi; 'appoint by show of hands', cheirotoneō; Acts 6:3, 14:23, Titus 1:5) rather than by election, with apostles and elders named first in Acts 15:22. On this reading governance is led by a body of elders with congregational assent. The vocabulary genuinely attests ruling elders, but 'lead/consider' (hēgeomai) and 'rule/preside' (proistēmi) are polysemous (carry more than one meaning) and 'submit' (hypeikō) is a hapax (a word that occurs only once in the entire Bible), so the scope of elder rule is not fixed by the words.

connectionalism: partly_supported · Reads Acts 15 as decisive: a translocal (across-location) council of apostles and elders with the Jerusalem church (ekklēsia) issues a decree ('it seemed good', edoxen; 'leading men', hēgoumenous, from hēgeomai) that is carried and imposed on assemblies in Antioch, Syria and Cilicia. On this reading authority extends beyond the single congregation to a wider body. The 'with' (syn) construction and the sending of the decree do attest translocal action, but the passage is a single narrative episode and does not lexically (at the word level) establish a standing connectional structure over local assemblies.

apostolic_foundationalism: complicates · Reads the apostolic and delegated initiative throughout ('we will appoint', katastēsomen, from kathistēmi; 'I have already judged', kekrika, from krinō, in the perfect tense, meaning a completed action whose result still stands; 'appoint by show of hands', cheirotoneō; 'direct' or 'order', diatassō; the Jerusalem decree) as a foundational authority not reducible to any ongoing polity (form of church government), which cautions against drawing any fixed constitutional pattern, congregational, presbyterian or connectional, from these narratives at all.

The lemmas (dictionary headword forms) attest both corporate (collective) participation in selection and discipline and authoritative direction by apostles, delegates (representatives) and ruling elders. The grammar names actors and sequences actions but does not adjudicate (decide between) which party holds final earthly authority, and the comparative 'best preserves' claim is an evaluative judgment outside lexical (word-level) reach. The three polity (church-government) lenses are stated symmetrically because the vocabulary underdetermines (does not fix) all three.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. How is governing authority distributed among the gathered assembly (ekklēsia), its appointed elders, and apostolic or delegated direction in the New Testament texts on selection, appointment and discipline, and where, if anywhere, does final earthly authority rest?

The stem asserts that one polity (form of church government) best preserves New Testament autonomy and accountability, embedding both a comparative ranking and the conclusion that final earthly authority rests in the gathered congregation under Christ with elders leading and the assembly affirming. The phrases 'best preserves' and the located 'final earthly authority' both preload a verdict. The verdict is derived on the original stem, but the neutralized form is the tradition-neutral question actually answerable from the lemmas (dictionary headword forms). Congregational, presbyterian and connectional readings are judged on the same lexical (word-level) footing.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
lexicon	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	G1577
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.6.3
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.15.22

morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Heb.13.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.5.17
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Titus.1.5
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.5.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.6.5
interlinear	SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no	Matt.18.17

License audit

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SBLGNT-text	SBLGNT-EULA	no

Flags

ecm-shadow · lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent